

MODULE 10 / 40

Dark-eyed Junco

Junco hyemalis

QUICK STATS

Length	5.5 – 6.3 in (14 – 16 cm)
Wingspan	7.1 – 9.8 in (18 – 25 cm)
Weight	0.6 – 1.1 oz (18 – 30 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 3 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Dark-eyed Junco is one of the most abundant birds in North America and a quintessential winter feeder visitor, earning its nickname "snowbird" for its tendency to appear at feeders just as the first cold weather arrives. Crisp and tidy in its dark gray-and-white plumage, it is among the easiest birds to identify — the sudden flash of white outer tail feathers as it flies away is one of the most recognizable field marks in North American birding. The Dark-eyed Junco is actually a complex of several regional forms that were once considered separate species, including the Slate-colored, Oregon, Pink-sided, and White-winged Juncos.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Dark-eyed Junco breeds across the boreal forests of Canada and Alaska, and in montane coniferous forests south through the Appalachians, Rockies, and Sierra Nevada. In winter it migrates south and can be found across virtually the entire contiguous United States, making it one of the most widespread winter birds on the continent. It favors woodland edges, brushy areas, and open ground near cover. In the breeding season it inhabits mature coniferous and mixed forests, often at higher elevations.

DIET & FEEDING

- White millet — strongly preferred, especially on the ground
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and cracked corn
- Milo, sorghum, and mixed seed blends
- Weed seeds: chickweed, sorrel, buckwheat
- Insects and spiders during breeding season
- Juncos are primarily ground feeders — scatter seed on the ground

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Dark-eyed Juncos are highly social in winter, forming flocks of 10–30 birds that maintain a clear dominance hierarchy. Males dominate females, and adults dominate young birds. Within a flock, subordinate individuals are pushed to the edges of feeding areas where predator risk is higher. Despite this hierarchy, flock members cooperate in vigilance — when one bird detects a threat and flushes, the flash of white tail feathers from multiple birds simultaneously serves as a visual alarm signal. Juncos are primarily ground feeders, hopping and scratching through leaf litter and snow with both feet simultaneously in a characteristic double-scratch motion.

NESTING & BREEDING

Juncos nest on or near the ground, often tucking their cup nest under an overhanging root, rock ledge, or clump of vegetation on a steep slope or bank. The female builds a neat cup of grasses, moss, and bark strips, lined with fine grasses and hair. Clutches of 3–5 eggs (pale bluish or grayish, spotted with brown) are incubated by the female for 12–13 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at just 9–13 days — unusually quickly, likely an adaptation to reduce nest predation risk. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The junco's song is a simple, pleasant musical trill on one pitch, similar to a Chipping Sparrow but slower and more musical. It is heard primarily on the breeding grounds. In winter flocks, juncos communicate with a variety of sharp "tick" and "smacking" call notes, as well as soft twittering calls within the flock. The sharp alarm call triggers the characteristic tail-flashing response.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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With an estimated population of 630 million individuals, the Dark-eyed Junco is one of the most numerous birds in North America. It is estimated that juncos make up roughly 71% of all birds at feeders across the US during winter. Population trends are stable across most of its range.

FEEDER TIPS

- Scatter white millet directly on the ground — juncos prefer ground feeding
- A low platform feeder or ground tray works better than tube feeders
- Clear snow from feeding areas — juncos struggle to dig through deep snow
- Dense shrubs nearby provide essential escape cover from hawks
- Juncos often arrive in mixed flocks with sparrows and chickadees

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Hood & back (male)	<i>Slate gray to dark charcoal</i>
Belly	<i>White — sharp contrast with hood</i>
Outer tail feathers	<i>White — flash when flying</i>
Female hood	<i>Paler brown-gray, less contrasted</i>
Bill	<i>Short, pale pink — conical</i>
Legs	<i>Pale pink</i>

COLOR ME!

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